



Page 1 of 7 · The Runaway Zero

Booklava closes the library alone and hears a papery sniffle. A zero is hiding beneath the reading rug. Without it, the number 40 on the shelf label has become 4.



Page 2 of 7 · Tens on the Stairs

The zero will return only if Booklava proves that every digit has a place. On the spiral stair she finds 6 bundles of ten books and 3 single books.



Page 3 of 7 · The Echoing Hall

A label marked 205 echoes through the hall. The zero worries that it means nothing. Booklava explains that it holds the empty tens place so the other digits cannot slide together.



Page 4 of 7 · A Taller Number

Booklava builds a ladder from number cards. The zero climbs between 3 hundreds and 7 ones, making a number far taller than 37.



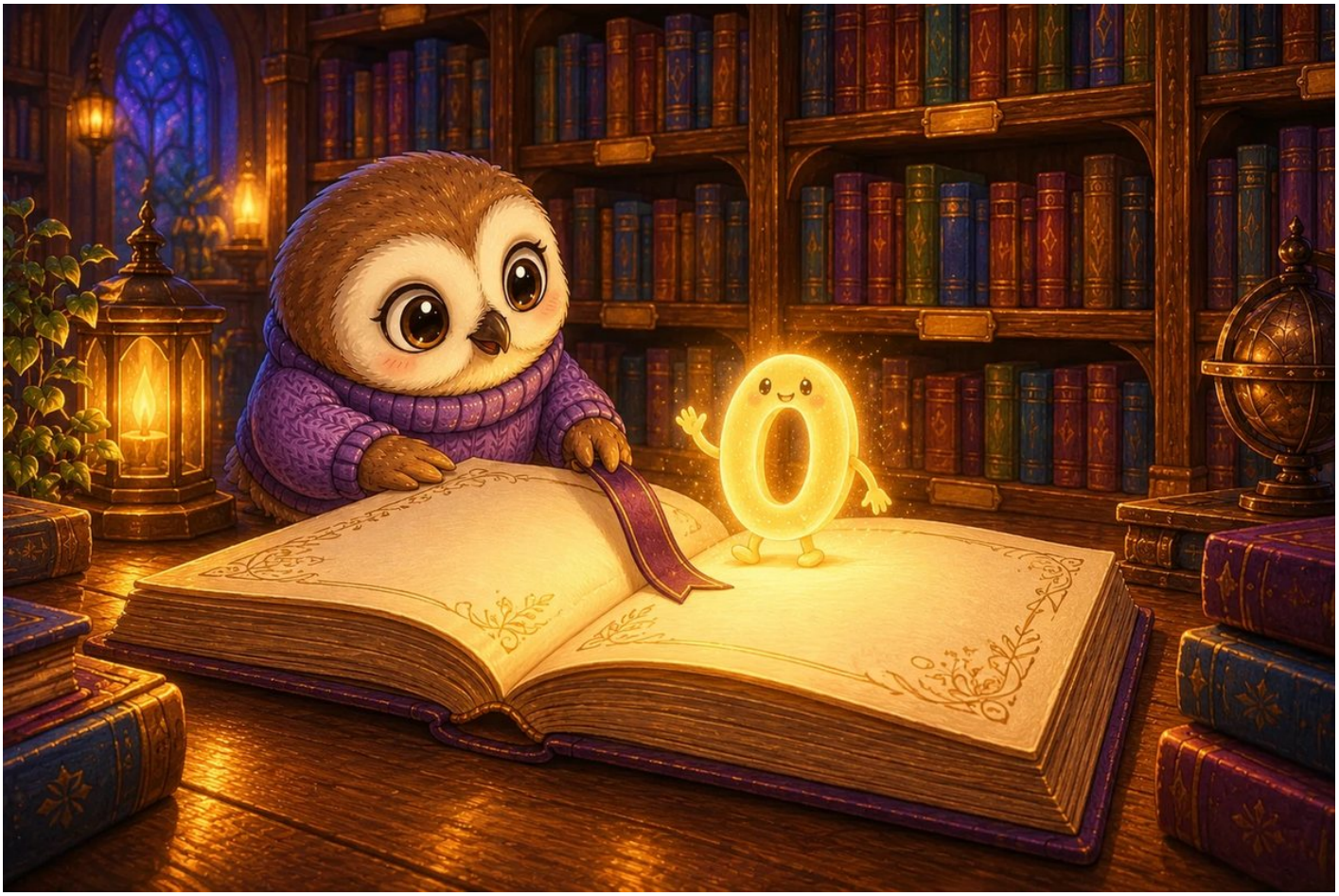
Page 5 of 7 · The Nearest Safe Shelf

A rolling book cart is labelled 68. It must stop at the nearest shelf marked in tens before it bumps the wall.



Page 6 of 7 · Zero Finds Its Voice

“I do not always add value,” says Zero, “but sometimes I hold a place.” Booklava nods. In 450, Zero keeps the 5 in the tens column.



Page 7 of 7 · Home Between the Pages

Zero slips back into the book. Every shelf label grows to its proper size. Booklava leaves a small bookmark beside the page: Every place matters—even an empty one.

Questions for Booklava and the Number That Lost Its Place

Read the story together first. Use one question at each page, then the question at the end. Answers are below the dotted line: fold them under or cover them while reading.

Page 1 · The Runaway Zero

In 40, what value does the digit 4 have?

Choices: 4 · 10 · 14 · 40

Page 2 · Tens on the Stairs

What number is 6 tens and 3 ones?

Choices: 36 · 60 · 63 · 603

Page 3 · The Echoing Hall

How many tens are in 205?

Choices: 0 · 2 · 5 · 20

Page 4 · A Taller Number

What number has 3 hundreds, 0 tens, and 7 ones?

Choices: 37 · 300 · 307 · 370

Page 5 · The Nearest Safe Shelf

What is 68 rounded to the nearest 10?

Choices: 60 · 68 · 69 · 70

Page 6 · Zero Finds Its Voice

What is the value of the digit 5 in 450?

Choices: 5 · 40 · 50 · 500

Page 7 · Home Between the Pages

Which is the largest number: 47, 74, 407, or 470?

Choices: 47 · 74 · 407 · 470

Answers (fold under before reading)

Page 1: 40. The 4 is in the tens place. Four tens are worth 40.

Page 2: 63. Six tens make 60. Add 3 ones: 60 + 3 = 63.

Page 3: 0. In 205, the digits mean 2 hundreds, 0 tens, and 5 ones. The zero holds the tens place.

Page 4: 307. Three hundreds are 300, zero tens add nothing, and 7 ones make 307.

Page 5: 70. The ones digit is 8, so round up. 68 is closer to 70 than 60.

Page 6: 50. The 5 is in the tens place. Five tens are worth 50.

Page 7: 470. Compare hundreds first. 407 and 470 both have 4 hundreds; compare tens next. Seven tens is greater than zero tens, so 470 is largest.

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